Go / Pivot / Kill: Decision Framework

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The hardest skill in entrepreneurship is knowing when to stop.

When to Use This

Use it whenever your team has to decide whether to continue, change direction or stop. The course runs it for the whole venture in Module 07. Decide in three moves, in this order.

1. **Your Kill Criteria Log decides first.** Lines you wrote before the data beat any score.
2. **The scorecard scores the rest.** Nine questions, each scored on an artifact, never on an opinion.
3. **Announce the verdict.** Go, Pivot or Kill, with the line or the score behind it.

A kill on evidence is a result, not a failure. The rubric says a rigorously argued kill can earn an A.

Step 1: Honour Your Kill Criteria Log

Every week since Module 00 you wrote lines into the Kill Criteria Log of your Student Toolkit. A kill line is a result you count, a date, and what you do if you cross it, written down before the data comes in.

Read every line next to its result.

- **A line you crossed decides.** Do what the line said, switch, pivot or kill.
- **Overriding a line needs evidence.** Name the artifact that justifies it and say plainly in your read-out that you overrode your own line.
- **A line written after the data is commentary,** not a line (Glossary, “Threshold”).

The scorecard only scores what the log leaves open.

Step 2: Score Nine Questions on Artifacts

Score each question 0, 1 or 2. Every score names its artifact, a sheet and row in your Toolkit, a recording, a dashboard. No artifact means 0, and that is a finding, not a missed week.

Score	Meaning
0	No evidence, only your opinion, or the evidence says no
1	Weak or mixed evidence
2	Strong evidence a stranger could check

Problem (max 6)

#	Question	2	1	0
1	Do people in one named segment describe this problem unprompted?	At least 3 of 10 raised it unprompted, across 10 or more conversations in that segment	At least 3 of 10, but from fewer than 10 conversations or mixed segments	Fewer than 3 of 10, or not logged
2	Do they spend time or money on a workaround today?	Money, named by the people who spend it	Time only	Nothing logged
3	Does the problem occur at least weekly for them?	Weekly or more, heard from named people	Less often, or heard from only some	Rare, or assumed

The line in question 1 is the course's default kill line from the Validation Hierarchy: "fewer than 3 out of 10 interviewees describe this problem unprompted". Read it from the Interview Log's "Raised unprompted?" column. Questions 2 and 3 read the Interview Log's "Cost today" column and your Pain Map.

Solution (max 6)

#	Question	2	1	0
4	Did people from your segment use your prototype without help?	They reached the outcome without you steering	They tried it but needed help or stopped before the outcome	Nobody outside the team tried it
5	Can you say why it is 10 times better, with proof?	One dimension, 10 times better, heard or measured	Better, but not 10 times, or heard from only a few	Assumed
6	Is there a reason this is possible now that was not two years ago?	A named change with a source, and your solution needs it	A change named, but not sourced or not needed	None

Question 4 reads your use records, one row per user, as Module 06 kept them. Question 5 is the 10x Value Proposition Test.

Traction (max 6)

#	Question	2	1	0
7	Has anyone paid?	Money from someone outside your social graph, any amount, including a paid deposit or pre-order	An unpaid pre-order, a signed letter of intent or another ask that cost them something	Interest only
8	Do users come back without you pushing them?	Users came back unprompted, more than one of them or more than once, dated in your use records	One return, or returns only after a reminder	Nobody came back unprompted, or no use records
9	Is at least one metric growing week over week?	A count of people from your segment grew in each of the last two weeks or more	It grew once, or only views and likes grew	Flat, falling or not tracked

Question 7 follows the Glossary. Only an opened wallet validates. A pre-order without payment or a letter of intent is signal. Question 9 reads the KPI Tracker.

Reading the Score

The total runs from 0 to 18. The zones are the default verdict.

Total	Default verdict	What it means
14 to 18	**Go**	Real signal on all three. Stop exploring, sell the thing
9 to 13	**Pivot**	Something works, something does not. Change the weakest part, one thing at a time
0 to 8	**Kill**	The evidence does not carry the venture. Run the Kill Ritual and restart

You may depart from the zone only with evidence you name in your read-out. “We have a good feeling” is not evidence.

Which pivot. Read the three sections, not only the total.

- **Problem weak.** Go back to the problem space, a **type 2 pivot**. It takes longer and needs a clean cut.
- **Problem strong, solution or traction weak.** Find another solution to the same problem, a **type 1 pivot**. Another form, another segment within the problem, another price model.

Change one thing at a time. If you change everything, you are not pivoting, you are starting over, which is fine after a kill.

Step 3: Announce the Verdict

Say it out loud, in class or to your team, with three things.

1. **The verdict,** Go, Pivot or Kill, and for a pivot its type.
2. **What decided it,** the crossed line from your Kill Criteria Log, or the score with its weakest section.
3. **What you test next,** with its own line, written before the first result.

When a test is still running, the verdict is provisional. You confirm or change it when the test has run, against the line you wrote before it.

The Kill Ritual

When you kill, a venture, a solution or a feature nobody used, write one page.

1. **What the evidence said.** Specifically, with the artifacts, not “it didn’t work”.
2. **Which line it crossed.** The line from your Kill Criteria Log, with its date.
3. **What surprised us.** The most interesting finding nobody expected.
4. **What we’d tell the next founder.** Three sentences.

The page turns a kill into an asset. The next idea often comes from the surprise. See the A-grade kill autopsy, a made-up example.

Restart After a Kill

The course does not stop when your venture does. Restart from your own records, not from a blank page.

1. **Read what seven weeks produced.** Problems people raised unprompted, segments that answered, channels that brought people.
2. **Pick the strongest asset,** often a channel or a segment rather than the product.
3. **Make a concierge offer.** Deliver the outcome by hand, no product, with a price (Glossary, “Concierge”).
4. **Name the people** from your records you will offer it to.

Module 08 sells it, like every other team’s offer.

Before You Decide: the Pre-Mortem

Imagine your venture is dead one year from now, and write down why (Module 00 did this with your starting idea).

1. **Write alone first.** Every founder lists causes of death, silently.
2. **Turn each cause into an assumption** about the customer, the solution or the business. In a made-up example, “recruiters won’t pay” becomes “recruiters pay for a nudge their applicant tracking system does not send”.
3. **Check each against your evidence.** Keep only the causes your records have not ruled out.
4. **Sort what is left** by how critical it is and how much you already know. The critical unknown is your monkey (Glossary, “Monkey first”). Test it first, with a line written before the first result.

For a single experiment, run the same move with the end of the test as the horizon.